

THREE ENDINGS: FITZGERALD,
HEMINGWAY, FAULKNER

by

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THE original endings of three important American novels, recovered from surviving manuscripts and typescripts, have been restored in scholarly editions. Each restoration involves two marks of punctuation. The novels are F. Scott Fitzgerald's *This Side of Paradise* (1920), Ernest Hemingway's *The Sun Also Rises* (1926), and William Faulkner's *The Wild Palms* (1939), which Faulkner wanted to call *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*. The punctuation marks are a period and a one-em dash for *This Side of Paradise*, a question-mark and a period for *The Sun Also Rises*, and a two-em dash and an exclamation point for *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*. An examination of the three endings, as first published and as later restored, will demonstrate how marks of punctuation can affect the interpretation of literary works. The editions to which the original endings have been restored are all "intentionalist" editions. Each of these editions attempts to capture the intentions of the author for the text at the time it was submitted, as a fair-copy typescript, to its publisher.

THIS SIDE OF PARADISE

Fitzgerald began composing his first novel in the fall of 1917. He was living with his friend John Biggs, Jr., at Princeton University, marking time until his army officer's commission was approved. He had decided not to continue as a student. When the United States declared war on Germany in April 1917, he answered the call to colors, enlisting (along with most of the rest of his class) in the armed forces. In late July he took the test for a commission in the army. In September he returned to the university and took up residence in a dormitory room with Biggs. During his final few weeks on campus, Fitzgerald attended lectures in English and history and helped with various chores on the *Nassau Literary Magazine*, of which Biggs was the editor.

Fitzgerald's first instinct was to compose his novel entirely in verse, but he quickly abandoned that notion and decided instead to employ a blend of prose, poetry, and drama dialogue. His novel was to be a bildungsroman; its working title was "The Romantic Egotist." Fitzgerald meant to trace the passage from adolescence to young manhood of his hero, a young aesthete named Stephen Palms, who was the first-person narrator. Fitzgerald produced three chapters at Princeton. His commission came through in late October, and he reported to training camp at Fort Leavenworth, Kansas, in November. There he resumed work on his manuscript. Three years later he recalled the process:

Every Saturday at one o'clock when the week's work was over I hurried to the Officers' Club, and there, in a corner of a roomful of smoke, conversation and rattling newspapers, I wrote a 120,000-word novel on the consecutive week-ends of three months. There was no revising; there was no time for it. As I finished each chapter I sent it to a typist in Princeton.¹

By February 1918 Fitzgerald had in hand a finished typescript of "The Romantic Egotist."² In March he submitted it to Charles Scribner's Sons. There the novel caught the attention of a young editor named Maxwell Perkins, who recognized the author's inventiveness and talent. Perkins' enthusiasm, however, was not enough to carry the day. The other editors at the firm were skeptical about Fitzgerald's novel; they considered it to be garrulous and immature, poorly structured and overburdened with detail. The rejection letter to Fitzgerald, dated 19 August 1918, put special emphasis on the ending of "The Romantic Egotist." The letter reads in part: "[T]he story does not seem to us to work up to a conclusion;—neither the hero's career nor his character are shown to be brought to any stage which justifies an ending." And the letter continues: "It seems to us in short that the story does not culminate in anything as it must to justify the reader's interest as he follows it; and that it might be made to do so quite consistently with the characters and with its earlier stages."³ Fitzgerald, now stationed at Camp Sheridan, Alabama, was troubled by this letter. "How could I intrigue the hero into a 'philosophy of life,'" he later wrote, "when my own ideas were in much the state of Alice's after the hatter's tea-party?"⁴

The armistice that ended the war was signed on 11 November 1918. Fitzgerald, who did not "make it over" to Europe, was discharged in February 1919. After an unsuccessful five-month stint as a copy-writer at the Barron Collier advertising agency in New York City, he quit his job and went home to St. Paul, Minnesota. There, in a third-floor room in his parents' house, he set about re-writing his novel. He took the best parts of "The Romantic Egotist" and added freshly composed material; he also incorporated the typescripts of a short story, a one-act play, and several poems into the narrative—most of this material originally written at Princeton. At Perkins' suggestion he dropped the breathless first-person narration of "The Romantic Egotist" and shifted to a more mature third-person voice. He changed the protagonist's name from Stephen Palms to Amory Blaine and altered the title to *This Side of Paradise*, a phrase taken from the penultimate line of Rupert Brooke's poem "Tiare Tahiti."⁵ The result was a fast-moving narrative, loosely unified, and crowded with characters and inci-

1. "Who's Who—and Why," *Saturday Evening Post* 193 (18 September 1920): 61; collected in *My Lost City*, ed. James L. W. West III (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 2005): 4.

2. Typescript fragments of "The Romantic Egotist" survive in Fitzgerald's papers at the Department of Special Collections, Princeton University Library.

3. *Correspondence of F. Scott Fitzgerald*, ed. Matthew J. Bruccoli, Margaret M. Duggan, and Susan Walker (New York: Random House, 1980): 31. The letter, signed "Charles Scribner's Sons," was probably written by Maxwell Perkins.

4. From Fitzgerald's preface to *This Side of Paradise*, in *This Side of Paradise*, ed. James L. W. West III (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1995): 394.

5. "Tiare Tahiti," in *1914 and Other Poems* (London: Sidgwick and Jackson, 1915): 19-21.

dents. Fitzgerald was sure that this novel, now nearly complete in manuscript, had caught the mood of his post-war generation.

Still there was the problem of the ending. *This Side of Paradise* was a coming-of-age story: how was Fitzgerald to bring the novel to a satisfactory conclusion when his hero's life was only getting under way? Under pressure he improvised a solution. In the last chapter of the novel, he sent Amory on a long walk from New York City to Princeton. Along the way Amory contemplates his current situation: he is penniless and unemployed but unwilling to pursue a conventional course in life. Almost his only achievement, he believes, is a hard-won self-knowledge. He arrives in Princeton long after midnight and contemplates the towers and spires of the university. "Here was a new generation, shouting the old cries, learning the old creeds, through a reverie of long days and nights," Amory muses, "a new generation dedicated more than the last to the fear of poverty and the worship of success; grown up to find all gods dead, all wars fought, all faiths in man shaken...."⁶ Amory stretches out his arms to the "crystalline, radiant sky":

"I know myself," he cried, "but that is all—"

The dash, in Fitzgerald's hand at the end of the manuscript, addresses the criticism in the rejection letter. The dash captures the unfinished nature of the novel and makes it clear that everything in Amory's life so far has been preliminary (see figure 1).

Somewhere between manuscript and first print, the dash became a period. No evidence survives to reveal who made the change. The manuscript, made up of heavily revised holograph and typescript sheets, is preserved among Fitzgerald's papers in the Department of Special Collections at Princeton.⁷ The document, messy and difficult to follow, is not a fair copy. A typescript made from this manuscript served as setting copy, but that typescript does not survive, nor do galleys or page proofs. The change from dash to period might therefore have been made anywhere along the line of textual transmission: by Fitzgerald's typist (Fitzgerald could not type), by a Scribner copy-editor, or by Perkins. Fitzgerald himself might have made the change, either on the setting copy or in proof, or he might have accepted the alteration after it was urged upon him by Perkins, though there is no letter from the editor to Fitzgerald in which this change is suggested.⁸ The first edition of the novel, published on 26 March 1920, ends with a period (see figure 2).

The presence of the dash in the last line of the manuscript was first noted in my dissertation.⁹ In 1982 I included a discussion of the dash and period in a

6. Cambridge edition, 260. I have emended "Gods" to "gods" in this quotation.

7. The manuscript can be viewed in a full-color digital reproduction on the Special Collections website at Princeton. The manuscript of *This Side of Paradise* and the typescript fragments of "The Romantic Egotist" are both published in black-and-white facsimile in *F. Scott Fitzgerald Manuscripts*, vol. I, parts 1 and 2, ed. Matthew J. Bruccoli (New York and London: Garland Publishing, Inc., 1990).

8. Letters between Fitzgerald and Perkins concerning the production and proofing of *This Side of Paradise* are published in *Dear Scott/Dear Max: The Fitzgerald-Perkins Correspondence*, ed. John Kuehl and Jackson R. Bryer (New York: Scribner, 1971): 17-30.

9. "Materials for an Established Text of F. Scott Fitzgerald's *This Side of Paradise*." Diss., University of South Carolina, 1971, p. 42.

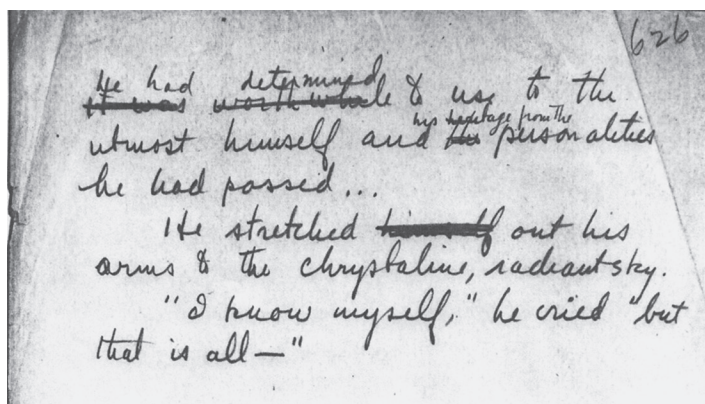


FIGURE 1. From final page of the manuscript, *This Side of Paradise*. F. Scott Fitzgerald Papers, Department of Special Collections, Princeton University Library.

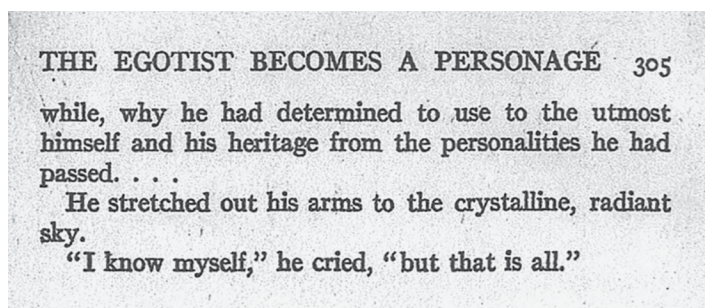


FIGURE 2. From final page of the first edition, *This Side of Paradise*. Charles Scribner's Sons, 1920.

monograph derived from the dissertation.¹⁰ All editions of *This Side of Paradise*, however, continued to end with the period until 1995. In that year I published a full-dress edition of the novel with Cambridge University Press as the third volume in The Cambridge Edition of the Works of F. Scott Fitzgerald. The text of this edition ends with a dash. The strongest evidence for the dash is the manuscript leaf, which is inscribed in Fitzgerald's hand. The period, by contrast, could have been introduced by anyone involved in the making of the book. For the Cambridge edition, I chose the dash.

The final punctuation mark has an effect on how the novel is read and interpreted. With the period, the novel comes to an abrupt halt. ("I know myself," he cried, "but that is all.") Self-knowledge has been achieved. Amory's education is finished; his young manhood is over; he is ready to face whatever life brings. With the dash the novel is open-ended and the conclusion more hesitant. ("I

10. *The Making of This Side of Paradise* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1982): 73-80.

know myself," he cried, but that is all—" Amory knows himself, or believes that he does, but that is all he is confident of knowing. He is still fundamentally the same person—idle, romantic, inquisitive, skeptical, unwilling to conform. Perhaps there is a place in society for him, but this is far from certain. Only the first part of Amory's life has been completed. The dash dovetails with the title—*This Side of Paradise*. The reader has followed Amory's journey to the beginnings of adulthood; what will come next we do not know.

The 1995 Cambridge text, ending with the dash, was published with the approval of the F. Scott Fitzgerald Literary Trust. This text was adopted by Scribner as its standard text and was first reprinted as a paperback by that publisher in 1996. The text with the dash has appeared in all Scribner editions from that date to the present.

THE SUN ALSO RISES

Ernest Hemingway began work on his first novel in mid-July 1925, shortly after attending, for the third time, the annual bullfighting fiesta in the Spanish town of Pamplona. He worked steadily on the novel through July and August and finished an autograph first draft on 21 September 1925. His working title was "Fiesta: A Novel." Hemingway (who, unlike Fitzgerald, could type) prepared a typescript from his manuscript. This typescript does not survive, but it must have existed. The differences between the holograph and the setting-copy typescript, which is extant, are so great that at least one revised typescript (and possibly more than one) must have intervened. Hemingway used a professional typing service for preparation of the setting copy. He made a very few emendations in his own hand on the finished sheets. The typescript, a fair copy bearing the title *The Sun Also Rises*, was put into the transatlantic mail to Maxwell Perkins at Scribner on 24 April 1926.¹¹ This is the document that served as setting copy for the first edition; it survives today in the Papers of Ernest Hemingway at the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. (The manuscript is preserved in the Ernest Hemingway Collection, John F. Kennedy Presidential Library and Museum.¹²) The compositors at the Scribner Press added handwritten galley "takes" to the setting copy—markings that indicate where each galley begins and ends—but this typescript was not otherwise marked before the type was assembled. All changes between the setting copy and the first edition must therefore have taken place in proof. Neither galleys nor page proofs, however, are known to survive.

The Sun Also Rises is the quintessential "lost generation" novel. It portrays the enervation and nihilism of the generation that had lived through the Great War. Much of the novel is presented in dialogue; the exchanges between characters are flat and unemotional, though a great deal is happening beneath the surface.

11. *The Letters of Ernest Hemingway*, vol. 3, ed. Rena Sanderson, Sandra Spanier, and Robert W. Trogdon (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 2015): 64–66. Hemingway was living in Paris during the proofing of the novel.

12. This manuscript has been published in facsimile: Ernest Hemingway, *The Sun Also Rises: A Facsimile Edition*, ed. Matthew J. Bruccoli. Archive of Literary Documents II. (Detroit: Omnigraphics, 1990).

The protagonist and first-person narrator is Jake Barnes, a journalist who has been wounded during the war. The wound has left him incapable of sex. He is in love with Brett Ashley, a decadent British aristocrat who seems to return his feelings, but they are unable to consummate their love.

At the very end of the novel, Jake and Brett are together in a taxi-cab. His arm is around her, and she is resting her head on his shoulder. "Oh, Jake," she says, "we could have had such a damned good time together." Jake's answer in the manuscript is ironic: "Yes," he says. "It's nice as hell to think so." The sentence ends with a period. At the bottom of this same manuscript page, the final leaf of the document, Hemingway has written an alternate version of the line: "Isn't it nice to think so"—with no terminal punctuation. In the setting-copy typescript, prepared by the typing service, the final line is worded differently but still ends with a period, though the period is typed outside the quotation marks. ("Isn't it pretty to think so".)¹³ The final line of the first edition, published by Scribner on 22 October 1926, ends on page 259 with a question-mark. ("Isn't it pretty to think so?") (See figures 3, 4, and 5).

No evidence survives to indicate who changed the period to a question-mark. Hemingway received galley proofs from Perkins on 11 August 1926 and returned them, with corrections, on 27 August.¹⁴ As I have mentioned, these galleys do not survive, nor do page proofs. The extant correspondence between Perkins and Hemingway concerns various textual matters—the use of profanity and of real names primarily. *The Sun Also Rises* was bowdlerized in proof. Three instances of "bulls have no balls" in Book Two, chapter 16, were altered to "bulls have no horns" (first edition, pp. 181–82). In the letters between Hemingway and Perkins, however, there is no mention of the final punctuation mark.¹⁵ *The Sun Also Rises* was published on 22 October 1926.

It seems probable that someone at Scribner, working on a form of proof, introduced the question-mark. Grammatically the sentence is a rhetorical question and does not require a question-mark. Still the mark was added, perhaps as part of a house style being imposed on the text. This interpretation is supported by twelve other rhetorical questions in the novel, all of them occurring in passages of dialogue, and all ending with periods in Hemingway's manuscript and setting-copy typescript. All twelve, like the final line of the novel, end with question-marks in the first edition.

Some examples will be helpful. In Book One, chapter 3, Jake and Brett are drinking at a café with friends. Brett becomes tipsy. "You're wonderfully sober," says Jake to Brett. She answers: "Yes. Aren't I. And when one's with the crowd I'm with, one can drink in such safety, too." In both the manuscript and the setting copy there is a period after "Aren't I." In the first edition, on page 22,

13. Commas and periods are consistently typed outside the quotation marks in the typescript, suggesting that the typist at the typing service was British, or that the typists who worked there were accustomed to using British styling. See figure 4. Some of the typescripts of short stories that Fitzgerald wrote in Paris in the 1920s also have British spelling and accidentals. Perhaps he and Hemingway, who were friends during those years, used the same typing service.

14. *Letters*, vol. 3, pp. 106, 109.

15. Hemingway's letters to Perkins during the production and proofing of the novel are in *Letters*, vol. 3, pp. 39–145.

together."

Ahead was a mounted policeman in khaki directing traffic. The car slowed suddenly pressing Brett close against me.

"Yes," I said. "It's nice as hell to think so."

The End.

Paris - Sept. 21 - 1925

"Isn't it nice to think so?"

FIGURE 3. From final page of the manuscript, *The Sun Also Rises*. Ernest Hemingway Collection, John F. Kennedy Presidential Library and Museum.

Ahead was a mounted policeman in khaki directing traffic. He raised his baton. The car slowed suddenly pressing Brett against me.

"Yes", I said. "Isn't it pretty to think so".

THE END

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FIGURE 4. From final page of the setting copy, *The Sun Also Rises*. Papers of Ernest Hemingway, Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia.

THE SUN ALSO RISES 259

Ahead was a mounted policeman in khaki directing traffic. He raised his baton. The car slowed suddenly pressing Brett against me.

"Yes," I said. "Isn't it pretty to think so?"

FIGURE 5. From final page of the first edition, *The Sun Also Rises*. Charles Scribner's Sons, 1926.

there is a question-mark: "Aren't I?" Another example occurs near the end of the novel, in Book Two, chapter 17. Here Robert Cohn, who has had a brief affair with Brett, asks Jake to forgive him. "So long, Jake," says Cohn. "You'll shake hands, won't you?" In the manuscript Jake answers: "Sure. Why not." In the setting copy the punctuation is the same (though the period after "not" is typed outside the quotation marks). On page 202 of the first edition Jake says: "Sure. Why not?" These two examples are typical of the other rhetorical questions to which question-marks have been affixed between the setting copy and the first edition. One's sense is that Hemingway, for these readings, wanted the characters to speak in a flat tone, without animation.

The matter is of some importance. As one reads dialogue in a text, one hears the rhythms and intonations of the spoken words by paying attention to the pointing, the accidentals. The voice of the character who is speaking rises and falls according to the punctuation. With the period at the end of the novel, Jake delivers his statement in a resigned tone. ("Isn't it pretty to think so.") This is consistent with his character and with the view he has come to take toward life. The question-mark, however, changes the way one hears the sentence. ("Isn't it pretty to think so?") Jake's voice rises at the end, making his statement sound flippant. This is out of character for him. He is bitter but is careful not to let his bitterness show. The final line, spoken without emotion, is in keeping with his behavior elsewhere in the novel.

Which punctuation mark should an editor choose for an edition of *The Sun Also Rises*? Here, as with *This Side of Paradise*, the editor must take a chance. How one hears the final line counts in the decision, as does one's reading of Jake's character. Documentary evidence, however, is a more reliable basis for editorial choice. The decision here seems straightforward. The period is present, in Hemingway's hand, in the final line of the manuscript. The period is also present in the fair copy that Hemingway submitted to Scribner. For twelve other rhetorical questions the same thing happened: periods in manuscript and fair copy were replaced by question-marks in the first edition. The periods should be restored to the text.

Every edition of *The Sun Also Rises* published between 1926 and 2020 has question-marks following the rhetorical questions. All of these editions end with: "Isn't it pretty to think so?" In 2018 the Library of America persuaded Scribner and the Hemingway estate to allow inclusion of *The Sun Also Rises*, which was nearing the end of its copyright protection, in a volume of early writings by Hemingway. The texts were prepared by Robert W. Trogdon, who consulted the surviving manuscripts, typescripts, and proofs for the writings in the volume. In the Trogdon text of *The Sun Also Rises*, the periods at the ends of the rhetorical questions are restored, as are the three instances of "bulls have no balls." The final line of this edition reads: "Isn't it pretty to think so."¹⁶

The Sun Also Rises entered the public domain on 1 January 2022. Shortly thereafter, the Library of America published a paperback edition of the Trogdon

16. Hemingway, *The Sun Also Rises & Other Writings, 1918–1926*, ed. Robert W. Trogdon (New York: Library of America, 2020). The emendations are recorded in the apparatus to this volume. The readings that involve the punctuation of rhetorical questions occur at 389.3, 397.18, 401.22, 414.33, 432.24, 432.40, 437.30, 487.20, 506.4, 516.32, 527.34, 567.37, and 570.8 of the text.

text, ending with the period. This paperback includes a selection of Hemingway's journalism and letters from 1925–1926.¹⁷ It is essential, after restoring a text, to make it available to readers in a reasonably priced edition. This has happened for *This Side of Paradise* and for *The Sun Also Rises*. As we shall see, it has happened also for *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*.

IF I FORGET THEE, JERUSALEM

William Faulkner's eleventh novel, published on 19 January 1939, has a complicated textual history. Faulkner wrote the novel under the title *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*.¹⁸ Random House, his publisher, changed the title to *The Wild Palms*. The novel consists of two interwoven stories, in alternating chapters. The primary narrative, entitled "The Wild Palms," is tragic; the secondary narrative, "Old Man," is comic. "The Wild Palms" is set in 1937. It tells the story of a woman and a man, Charlotte Rittenmeyer and Harry Wilbourne, who resolve to free themselves from the burdens and constraints of society. Charlotte, a wife and mother, leaves her husband and two children; Harry, an unmarried medical student, abandons his studies and follows Charlotte in pursuit of what she conceives to be freedom. Their first few months together go well, but their idyll cannot endure. Charlotte becomes pregnant, and Harry (at her urging) performs an abortion. He botches the operation; Charlotte dies of hemorrhaging; Harry is sentenced to fifty years in prison. He refuses to commit suicide and decides to live out his years in captivity. Harry resolves to keep Charlotte alive in memory. The final line of "The Wild Palms," in italicized interior monologue, gives his decision:

"Between grief and nothing I will take grief."

The secondary story, "Old Man," is a comic fable. The characters have no names: the protagonist is called "the tall convict," and the woman is simply "the woman" or "she." "Old Man" is set during the severe flooding of the Mississippi River in 1927. The tall convict has been temporarily released from prison in order to rescue people stranded by the flood. He takes a skiff and paddle and sets out on the river. He finds a pregnant woman clinging to a tree and helps her into the boat. For the remainder of "Old Man," he and she are tossed about on the powerful river, coming to rest briefly on a small island where, with his assistance, she gives birth. The tall convict performs heroically during his period of freedom. He saves the woman and brings her and the baby to dry land. Throughout the narrative, however, he seems terrified of the woman and of what she represents. His only desire is to return to captivity. He fears the disorder and messiness of life and prefers the regularity of imprisonment; he has no desire to complicate his existence with women, and certainly not with sex or childbirth. In Faulkner's manuscript and in the setting-copy typescript, which he typed, "Old Man" ends

17. Hemingway, *The Sun Also Rises: The Library of America Corrected Text*, ed. Robert W. Trogdon (New York: Library of America, 2022).

18. The title is an allusion to Psalms 137: "By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion." Images and wording from this psalm, which concerns captivity and freedom, appear throughout Faulkner's novel.

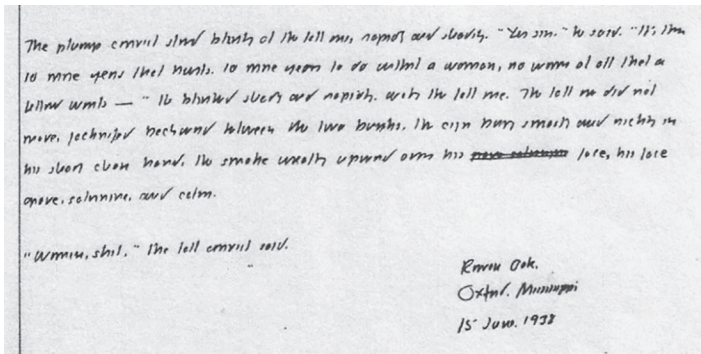


FIGURE 6. From final page of the manuscript, *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*. Papers of William Faulkner, Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia.

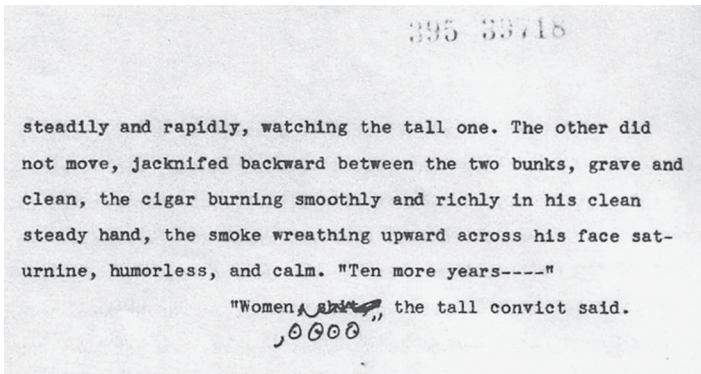


FIGURE 7. From final page of the setting copy, *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*. Papers of William Faulkner, Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia.

with the convict back in prison (see figures 6 and 7). Another ten years have been added to his sentence. He seems content, even pleased, with his fate. When asked by another inmate whether he will miss the company of women, his reply (the last line of the novel) is quite different from Harry's last line:

"Women, shit," the tall convict said.

Faulkner began composing "The Wild Palms" and "Old Man" as two separate stories but soon realized that the narratives were related to each other, not by plot and character but by theme and image. Both stories are about freedom versus imprisonment, the disorder of life versus the security of incarceration. Faulkner now began writing the novel in alternating stints, bringing "The Wild Palms" to a point of high intensity, then shifting to the comedy of "Old Man," then returning to the drama of "The Wild Palms," and onward until the end of

the novel. The manuscript, composed between September 1937 and June 1938, survives among Faulkner's papers at the Small Special Collections Library. The pagination of the document confirms that Faulkner wrote the two stories in alternating chapters, composing a chapter of one and then a chapter of the other. He did not write "The Wild Palms" in its entirety, then write "Old Man," and then shuffle the chapters. This structural experimentation was characteristic of Faulkner's work from the late 1920s until the early 1940s, a period that saw publication of *The Sound and the Fury* (1929), *As I Lay Dying* (1930), *Absalom, Absalom!* (1936), *The Hamlet* (1940), and *Go Down, Moses* (1942)—all of which take liberties with conventional narrative structure.

Faulkner's publisher, however, seems not to have understood what he was doing. Saxe Commins, Faulkner's editor at Random House, changed the title of the novel from *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*, an inclusive title, to *The Wild Palms*, the title of the primary story. The change in title, made over Faulkner's objections, caused confusion for many years after publication. Scholars and critics did not recognize *The Wild Palms* as a novel. The history of subsequent editions did not help matters. In 1948 both "The Wild Palms" and "Old Man" were issued separately, in individual paperback volumes.¹⁹ In a 1954 paperback the two narratives were published together but one after the other, with the full text of "The Wild Palms" appearing first, followed by "Old Man" in its entirety.²⁰

The novel was also bowdlerized. Faulkner objected to this sanitizing but was overruled.²¹ The setting-copy typescript, like the manuscript, is among Faulkner's papers at the Small Special Collections Library.²² On the typescript Faulkner's editor has marked out the word "shit." He has preserved Faulkner's comma and has substituted four ellipsis points for the profane word. Proofs for the book do not survive, but further changes in the final line must have occurred there. On page 339 of the first edition, the final page of "Old Man" and of the novel, the comma and the ellipsis points have been replaced by an open two-em dash and an exclamation point (see figure 8). The final line now reads:

"Women ——" the tall convict said.

19. *The Wild Palms* (New York: New American Library, 1948); *The Old Man* (New York: New American Library, 1948). For these and later editions, the word "The" was added to the title of "Old Man."

20. *The Wild Palms and The Old Man* (New York: New American Library, 1954).

21. Faulkner had little leverage with his publisher in 1939. Random House was the fifth imprint to publish his work and was carrying him as a *succès d'estime*. His first book with Random House, *Absalom, Absalom!*, had not sold well; *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*, with another biblical title, was not likely to do better—hence, presumably, the change in title. In 1939 Faulkner was best known as the author of *Sanctuary* (1931), a scandalous novel about a young woman who is raped with a corn cob. It is not surprising that the publisher bowdlerized *The Wild Palms*. The sanitizing, however, was incomplete: the words "pricks" and "cunts" appear on p. 52 of the first edition, and "Shit!" appears on p. 101. Later, after he had won the Nobel Prize in 1949, Faulkner swung more weight at Random House, and the heavy editing of his texts ceased.

22. Both the manuscript and the setting-copy typescript of the novel have been published in facsimile in *William Faulkner Manuscripts*, vol. 14, parts 1 and 2, ed. Thomas L. McHaney (New York and London: Garland Publishing, Inc., 1986).

The open dash (i.e., preceded and followed by half-spaces) was presumably meant to stand for the word “shit.” Punctuation is often used in printed texts as a substitute for profanity, but the two-em dash here, with the exclamation point, does not suggest a profane word. The line instead conveys mild exasperation, or perhaps longing.

steadily and rapidly, watching the tall one. The other did not move, jackknifed backward between the two bunks, grave and clean, the cigar burning smoothly and richly in his clean steady hand, the smoke wreathing upward across his face saturnine, humorless, and calm. “Ten more years—”
“Women ——!” the tall convict said.

FIGURE 8. From final page of the first edition, *The Wild Palms*. Random House, 1939.

Further change occurred in subsequent typesettings. In the *Viking Portable Faulkner* (1946), the half-spaces have been removed.

“Women——!” the tall convict said.

The French translator, confused, rendered the line this way in 1952:

— *Ah ! Les femmes ! » dit le grand forçat.*²³

In the New American Library edition of 1954, the long dash becomes a closed one-em dash, with the exclamation point retained:

“Women—!” the tall convict said.

The Vintage paperback of 1962 is a slight improvement, with three hyphens and the letter “t” plus the exclamation point. It reads:

“Women---t!” the tall convict said.

These textual discoveries were noted first by Thomas L. McHaney in his dissertation in 1968.²⁴ Twenty-two years later, McHaney and Noel Polk, with the permission of Faulkner’s literary estate, collaborated on a corrected text of the novel that was published by the Library of America. Here the title of Faulkner’s work is given as *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem [The Wild Palms]*.²⁵ On the last page of this edition the final line has been restored. (“Women, shit,” the tall convict said.) Random House adopted this text, and indeed all of the corrected texts produced

23. *Les Palmiers sauvages* (Paris: Gallimard, 1952).

24. McHaney, “William Faulkner’s *The Wild Palms*: A Textual and Critical Study.” Diss. University of South Carolina, 1968. See especially Appendix I, “The Text,” pp. 252-65.

25. In the volume William Faulkner, *Novels 1936-1940* (1990): 493-726.

by Polk for the Library of America, in its subsequent editions of Faulkner's novels. Today, all copies published of *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*, which is still under copyright protection, end with the restored line. One hopes that the corrections will be carried forward in editions issued after the novel enters the public domain in 2035.

All editors hope to find significant variants in important works of literature. Editors want to discover variants that will alter meaning, or at least cause teachers and critics to rethink their ideas about interpretation. This is probably a legacy of the New Criticism, with its emphasis on close reading. The New Critics taught that each word carries meaning, as does each punctuation mark, and that the interpretation of a literary work can turn on a single sentence. Perhaps the New Critics were right. Some sentences in fiction bring immediately to mind the works in which they appear. ("Mr. Holmes, they were the footprints of a gigantic hound!") Some capture a central image. ("The red sun was pasted in the sky like a wafer.") Some sentences prepare the work for its conclusion. ("Marlow ceased, and sat apart, indistinct and silent, in the pose of a meditating Buddha.") Some sentences tie together all that has come before. ("Reader, I married him.") Other sentences, appearing at the very end of a work, encapsulate its meaning. ("He loved Big Brother.")

The discovery of pivotal variants is rare. Many excellent scholarly editions present texts that have been emended throughout, but the emendations are not especially significant. Documentary or "versionist" editions usually offer texts that are identical to, or not very different from, earlier texts. Facsimile editions typically list emendations at the foot of the page or in an apparatus. These editions can do many good things: they can provide narratives of composition and revision, trace the textual history of the work, and provide useful historical annotations. Time schemes are sometimes straightened out; the author's accidentals are reinstated; misspellings and other demonstrable errors are corrected. These are valuable services, but they do not provide a definitive response, if there is one, to the notion that scholarly editing is essentially clerical work. All editors have heard this sort of thing. Why should an editor undertake the considerable labor of a full-dress edition if the interpretation of the work is to remain unchanged? Important variants might indeed turn up in the collations, but an editor usually does not know this when beginning a project. The editor must proceed on faith.

In the case of these three final sentences, however, we do have variants of consequence. Each of these readings falls at the very end of its novel, and each involves punctuation. These are not minor works; they are important novels, taught in classrooms and interpreted by critics. How these changes came about—from dash to period, period to question-mark, profane word to long dash—these stories can be included in lectures and discussed with students, most of whom probably think that a literary work springs immaculate from its creator's brow. With a dash at the end of *This Side of Paradise*, the journey of its hero is just beginning. With a period at the end of *The Sun Also Rises*, the narrator takes a bleak but realistic view of his future. And with the word "shit" at the end of *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*, the tall convict's rejection of women, and of life, is made clear.

